commenced firing, not a man was known to be there'.[67] One of the casualties was 'Fighting Bob' himself, who had his leg shattered with the ball of a jezail within the first minute of the ambush. 'I could not help admiring old Sale's coolness,' said his Brigade Major. 'He turned to me and said, "Wade, I have got it," and then remained on horseback directing the skirmishers until compelled from loss of blood to make over command to Dennie.'[68]

Despite this, Sale's force pushed on down the Khord Kabul Pass, reinforced by more troops from Kabul and taking increasingly heavy casualties as they went, Sale again directing operations, this time from a palanquin. The worst losses took place during another night attack a week later on 17 October. Around 5 p.m., one of the Tezin chiefs sent a note to the British 'saying that they had arrived at the Tung-i-Tareekhi [the Dark Gorge], and that in two hours they would attack us. A polite reply was sent to the effect that we should be happy to receive the chiefs, and would endeavour to give them a suitable welcome.'[69] The note proved a stratagem: by telling the British to expect a frontal attack, and beginning to launch one, the Ghilzai managed to surprise the British when their main force appeared to the rear, where some of Shah Shuja's newly recruited Hazirbash cavalry had been bribed to let them within the camp: 'They were of the same tribe, and whilst the rest were fighting, these ever-ready gentlemen did a little work of their own, cutting downs surwans [camel drivers] and hamstringing camels.'[70]

That night Sale's brigade lost a further eighty-nine men, as well as much of their baggage and ammunition, which was removed to the Ghilzai fortress in Tezin on ninety of the Company's own camels. The expedition which was supposed to chastise the Ghilzais turned out to have a very different victim to that intended: in the narrow web of the mountain passes, the spider had become the fly; and the hunters found to their surprise and discomfort that they had now become the prey.

On the morning of 23 October, the beleaguered column advanced again, through an especially narrow part of the pass just before Tezin. Turning a corner around two huge rocks, 'the hills which bounded the valley on all sides were suddenly seen to swarm with Afghans'. By a combination of sniping from cover and well-timed rushes on the baggage train and rearguard, 'they again slew this day a great many more of our men, and carried off no inconsiderable portion of booty; of which it would be hard to